

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Downed wires & electrical hazards

HOME BUILDING / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Keep away from fallen wires, damaged electrical equipment and anything touching them, including water, fences and vehicles. Assume wires are live even when they are quiet or the neighbourhood has no power. Do not attempt a rescue by touching a person or object in contact with electricity. Contact the utility or emergency services from a safe place.

Do now.

- ☐ **Stay back**
01 Do not approach to determine whether a wire is live. Current can travel through wet ground and conductive objects. Keep others and animals away.
- ☐ **Avoid connected objects**
02 Do not touch fences, trees, vehicles or debris that may contact a wire. Do not use a stick or tool to move it.
- ☐ **Stay out of flooded electrical areas**
03 Never enter water to reach a breaker, appliance or person near damaged electrical systems. Use qualified help.
- ☐ **Warn from safety**
04 Tell people to avoid the area from your safe location. Report a clear location without approaching for a photograph.
- ☐ **Do not restore damaged systems**
05 Leave flooded, scorched or broken equipment off until qualified personnel assess it. A restored grid does not make damaged wiring safe.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

Keep the hazard avoided if the utility cannot be reached. Do not move a wire to open a road or restore access; arrange a different safe route.

Watch for.

Do not assume a fixed visible distance proves safety. Lines may reenergise without warning; no spark or hum is not an all-clear.

People & practical needs.

Assign a trusted adult to each person who needs assistance. Keep medicines, essential contacts and a workable reunion plan with the group. Make decisions around the least mobile person, not the fastest; avoid splitting the family without a clear, safe way to reconnect. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: stay back. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. Do not assume a fixed visible distance proves safety. Lines may reenergise without warning; no spark or hum is not an all-clear.

Keep essentials within reach.

For downed wires & electrical hazards, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: Keep the hazard avoided if the utility cannot be reached. Do not move a wire to open a road or restore access; arrange a different safe route. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

If a wire falls onto a vehicle you occupy, generally stay inside and call for help; fire or another immediate threat changes the decision. Follow qualified emergency instructions rather than touching the vehicle and ground together.

First decision: Stay back

Do not approach to determine whether a wire is live. Current can travel through wet ground and conductive objects. Keep others and animals away. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

Keep the hazard avoided if the utility cannot be reached. Do not move a wire to open a road or restore access; arrange a different safe route. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

Do not assume a fixed visible distance proves safety. Lines may reenergise without warning; no spark or hum is not an all-clear. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Keep away from fallen wires, damaged electrical equipment and anything touching them, including water, fences and vehicles. Assume wires are live even when they are quiet or the neighbourhood has no power. Do not attempt a rescue by touching a person or object in contact with electricity. Contact the utility or emergency services from a safe place. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For downed wires & electrical hazards, keep the specific hazard in view: Do not assume a fixed visible distance proves safety. Lines may reenergise without warning; no spark or hum is not an all-clear.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Do not restore damaged systems. Leave flooded, scorched or broken equipment off until qualified personnel assess it. A restored grid does not make damaged wiring safe. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

CDC · Protect yourself during a power outage

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/response/what-to-do-protect-yourself-during-a-power-outage.html>

CDC · Avoid carbon monoxide poisoning

<https://www.cdc.gov/natural-disasters/psa-toolkit/avoiding-carbon-monoxide-poisoning.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/downed-power-lines/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.